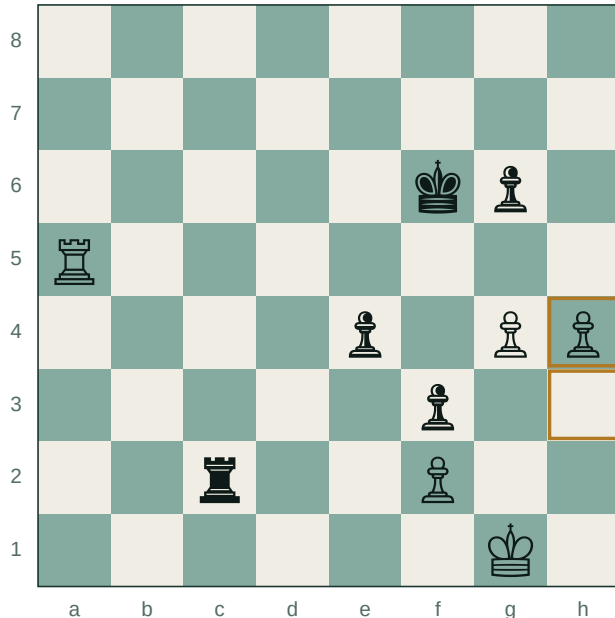


Rook-ending tactics: Black, move 52

Rook-ending tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 52.h4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

52...Rc1+ 53. Kh2 e3

52...Rc1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **53.Kh2**.

53...e3 The pawn moves from e4 to e3.

At the end, nominal material is White 8 / Black 8 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from +0 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a5. Check for tactical protection.